



The trust vote transforms Karat into a street-smart politician but causes rifts within the Left

■ By Shafi Rahman

Last week when Prakash Karat drove his mud-splashed white Ambassador car to meet with Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) supremo Mayawati in a surprise political move, it seemed like a new journey for the CPI(M) general secretary—from the walled garden of AKG Bhavan into the wilds of heartland politics proper. Karat's move came at a time when he was being increasingly isolated, with even leaders from his own flock raising objections to his decision to vote alongside the BJP against the UPA Government. By aligning with Mayawati, once the Left's bete noire, it seems Karat is trying to mold himself into a street smart politician to ensure the Congress does not end up winning the numbers game. Emerging out of the meeting, Karat declared: "Mayawati reiterated her opposition to the deal. It was decided that

there should be cooperation to stop the deal, and in the struggle against the UPA Government."

Karat is matching the brave words with some brave actions. He expects to fracture the Samajwadi Party (SP), a "natural ally" which ditched him midway, with the help of BSP. With the Left breaking away from the SP for the first time since 1989 and joining hands with Mayawati, the BSP will be able to scrape off some of the "anti-minority" patina earned with its association with the BJP. Though it will not mean much electorally for the Left, the move would embolden the Mayawati camp planning to woo fence-sitters prior to the crucial trust vote on July 22. The flowering political romance with Mayawati is only part of the picture. Karat's gameplan also includes wooing smaller parties which could swing the confidence vote away from the Congress. Parties like the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM), Janata Dal (S), Telangana Rashtra